05 THE LOUNGE & SILK SKY

DECISION GUIDE + BUILD

Reflecting-pool table, rippling linen overhead, and where people sit.

LEVEL	CREW	WHERE	STAGE NOW
■□□ Open to all	2–4	The old burned foundation (lower right)	Decisions: layout, seating, pool, fire

The Garden Table zone sits on the foundation of the structure that burned. At its center: a table with a sunken, dark reflecting pool, flush with a cream plaster top. Overhead: gathered panels of raw linen on four posts and beams, rippling in the wind, lit blue at night. Seating goes at the top edge (in front of the neighbor's wall) and at the far right on the grass. This guide sets out the decisions, so the building can follow. Hiba (architect, Amman) is consulted on the design.

FIRST STEPS *today*

1. Sweep and clear the slab of ash and debris. Tap-test the concrete and mark any hollow or cracked areas in chalk.
2. Measure the slab and the two seating spots. Draw a simple plan (graph paper is fine) for Yusuf and Hiba.
3. Mark the four post positions and the table footprint with chalk; sit in each seating spot and check the view and shade at different times of day.
4. Make a quick proof-of-concept: one rope between two points with one linen panel, to see how it moves.

BEFORE YOU START

- Inspect the slab before anything is built on it: tap with a hammer (a hollow sound means delaminated concrete), look for heat cracks and spalling, and clear all ash.
- Santa Ana winds: fabric panels must come down quickly. Use rings and carabiners, not knots.
- Red flag days: take the fabric down.

THE BASICS

Seating option A: majlis	Built-in low benches of earth or lime plaster along the two sides, with removable cushions on top. Cheap, permanent, fire-resistant, and in the same earthen language as the domes. In the Arab and Turkish garden tradition.
Seating option B: daybeds	Two freestanding daybeds. Luxurious, but they need covered storage and add burnable material under the fabric.
Seating option C: floor	Cushions and rugs on the ground. Most flexible, most upkeep.
Recommendation	Option A in the two seating spots, with removable cushions. Daybeds only if there's dry storage nearby.
Cushions, naturally	Removable, washable covers of heavy cotton canvas or linen; wool or kapok fill. Store in a lidded bin at night and in rain. Off-white, indigo and lapis fade gracefully in the sun.

HOW-TO NOTES

The pool table: still or spilling?	A mirror effect wants still, dark water. An infinity edge wants moving water spilling over a knife edge into a hidden channel. Pick one. A middle way: still surface with a barely visible overflow trickle. Keep it shallow (3–4 in), and make the rim perfectly level (water level or laser).
How it works	Basin lined with EPDM under plaster, or finished in tadelakt or marmorino lime plaster (traditionally waterproof), pigmented dark with iron oxide black or blue. A small buried reservoir and pump (solar DC works) recirculate. Moving water and Bti "mosquito dunks" keep mosquitoes away.
The silk sky	Four posts, beams, gathered panels of 5–7 oz linen (graceful movement, 3–4 year life). Rope first as proof-of-concept, stainless cable when permanent. Raw or white linen, uplit with blue LED at night.
The fire pit	Not under or near the fabric. In unincorporated LA County, recreational fires in wildfire-risk areas need a permit from the fire department, and red flag days rule them out. Options: a propane fire bowl set well away from the canopy, with the fire department's OK; or no flame at all: clay lanterns, the pool lit blue, solar lanterns.

THE PLAN *in order*

01	**Inspect + clear**	Slab tested, ash removed.
02	**Design**	Plan drawn, Hiba consulted, seating option chosen, pool type chosen.
03	**Posts + beams**	Footings, posts, beams; rope proof-of-concept with a few panels.
04	**Seating**	Earth or plaster benches built, or daybeds sourced.
05	**Pool table**	Basin, liner/plaster, reservoir, pump, level rim.
06	**Fabric**	Linen sourced (friend's shop), panels sewn with rings, hung with carabiners.
07	**Cushions + light**	Covers sewn, bins for storage, blue LED on solar.

TOOLS & MATERIALS

Hammer (for tap-testing), chalk, broom, shovel · Tape measure, graph paper · Rope, carabiners, rings · Linen samples · Water level or laser level

FOR YUSUF TO DECIDE

- ? Seating: majlis, daybeds or floor
- ? Pool: still mirror or infinity spill
- ? Fire pit: propane bowl away from canopy, or no flame
- ? Cushion fabric and fill
- ? Rope or cable (and when to switch)
- ? Lighting color and placement

Resources: LA County Fire Department (fire pit permits) (fire.lacounty.gov · (323) 881-2411)